

Report of the Ad Hoc Subcommittee on UFO Studies with Respect to IAA SETI Permanent Committee Business

In response to an online discussion on the community list regarding the rejection of UFO-related abstracts at a Permanent Committee meeting, this ad hoc subcommittee met to draft a document explaining the position of the Permanent Committee on the topic, and to recommend further actions.

There was considerable discussion and difference of opinion in the ad hoc subcommittee on both the nature of UFO research and its propriety for the Permanent Committee. Many members' positions were nuanced, but broadly speaking many felt that UFO studies were inherently inconsistent with the work of the committee and out of scope; others felt that UFO studies should be included if they could satisfy certain criteria for scientific rigor and relevance to the Permanent Committee's goals.

Several factors complicated the conversation. One was that the existing [terms of reference](#) explicitly exclude UFO studies, but the draft revision to the Terms of Reference circulated to the Committee by the executive on 28 November 2020 do not. Another is that a few UFO-related abstracts have been accepted in the past, and there was a strong desire from some members to lay out explicit criteria under which they would be accepted in the future.

A large majority of the subcommittee supported the Permanent Committee examining these potentially contentious issues in more detail, for instance through polling of the membership, defining the scope of the committee more precisely, and having more guidance regarding the acceptance criteria for abstracts.

A plurality of the subcommittee supported the following positions:

- UFO studies can, in principle, be conducted well and have significant scientific value
- UFO studies are generally out of scope for the Permanent Committee
 - One reason is that the PC has historically focused on astronomical and social aspects of SETI, which use different methods (astronomy and social science) than employed in UFO studies
 - Another reason is that UFO studies in general have not met the necessary evidentiary criteria for demonstrating that UFOs might have anything to do with alien technology
- There is no bar or prejudice against any PC member who, in addition to their work relevant to the PC, also engages in UFO-related research

Therefore, a majority of the subcommittee recommends that the Permanent Committee:

1. Change the wording of the scope of the committee in its terms of reference [Draft, 28 November 2020] to read that it “examines topics related to the possible existence of extant or extinct intelligent and/or technological life having arisen beyond Earth.” [i.e. strike “all” from “all topics”]. If that draft is not adopted and the old terms of reference are retained, similarly strike “all” from the second sentence of the old terms.
2. If the draft terms of reference are adopted, add a UFO exclusion reading “the committee’s work does not include studies of UFOs or Unidentified Aerial Phenomena” (i.e., maintain the exclusion that was in the original ToR.)
3. Adopt a statement (given below) explaining this exclusion
4. Convene a subcommittee or subcommittees charged with **some or all** of the following, at the PC’s discretion:
 - Defining the scope of work of the Permanent Committee
 - Formalizing the process by which abstracts are accepted or rejected
 - Polling Permanent Committee members on their positions regarding UFO research
 - Exploring the boundaries between UFO research and SETI, in particular the extent to which they complement or diverge from one another
 - Considering and making recommendations regarding whether to uphold, modify, or remove the exclusion on UFO research. This could, in principle, include laying out specific criteria whereby UFO abstracts would be accepted.

A minority of the subcommittee objects to a categorical bar against UFO-related research for the time being, even paired with a recommendation that the Permanent Committee re-examine that bar in the near future, and recommends that the PC reject the first two recommendations. This minority recommends that the PC:

1. Remove this sentence from the [terms of reference](#): “These terms of reference exclude any consideration of UFO phenomena.”
2. If the draft terms of reference from 2020 are adopted, then they should not include any statements that exclude the PC from consideration of UFO phenomena.
3. Draft a longer document that explains the criteria by which abstracts will be evaluated for relevance to the IAA SETI PC.
4. Consider performing further work to explore and constrain any boundaries between ongoing UFO studies and astronomical SETI. Such efforts could include building collaborations with existing organizations that engage in the scientific study of UFOs.

Attached below are the two reports from the subcommittee for the PC to consider when deciding which recommendations to follow.

Majority Report of the Ad Hoc Subcommittee on UFO Studies with Respect to IAA SETI Permanent Committee Business

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Summary:

In response to an online discussion on the community list regarding the propriety of UFO-related abstracts at Committee meetings, this ad hoc subcommittee met to draft a document explaining the exclusion of such work and to recommend further actions. There was considerable discussion and difference of opinion regarding where the boundary between UFO studies and the activities of the committee should lie. The majority opinion was to let the exclusion stand. We recommend slightly altering the terms of reference to reflect this, issuing a statement explaining the exclusion. We also recommend the committee consider an additional, longer document explaining the full scope of the committee. We acknowledge the interest of committee members and members of the community in more fully exploring the boundaries between UFO studies and astronomical SETI, including whether it should be moved.

Recommendations to the PC:

1. Change the wording of the scope of the committee in its terms of reference [Draft, 28 November 2020] to read that it “examines topics related to the possible existence of extant or extinct intelligent and/or technological life having arisen beyond Earth.” [i.e. strike “all” from “all topics”]. If that draft is not adopted and the old terms of reference are retained, similarly strike “all” from the second sentence of the old terms.
2. If the draft terms of reference are adopted, add a UFO exclusion reading “the committee’s work does not include studies of UFOs or Unidentified Aerial Phenomena” (i.e., maintain the exclusion that was in the original ToR.)
3. Adopt the below statement explaining this exclusion
4. Convene a subcommittee or subcommittees charged with **some or all** of the following, at the PC’s discretion:
 - Defining the scope of work of the Permanent Committee
 - Formalizing the process by which abstracts are accepted or rejected
 - Polling Permanent Committee members on their positions regarding UFO research
 - Exploring the boundaries between UFO research and SETI, in particular the extent to which they complement or diverge from one another
 - Considering and making recommendations regarding whether to uphold, modify, or remove the exclusion on UFO research. This could, in principle, include laying out specific criteria whereby UFO abstracts would be accepted.

Statement:

The Permanent Committee on SETI for the International Academy of Astronautics “examines topics related to the possible existence of extant or extinct intelligent and/or technological life having arisen beyond Earth.” The question has arisen as to why the committee does not consider the study of Unidentified Flying Objects (i.e. UFOs, or the related concept of Unidentified Aerial Phenomena or UAPs) to be within its purview. Indeed, given that there is a popular association of them with alien technology, it is understandable that it seems strange to many that the committee does not include the investigation of UFOs as having extraterrestrial origin in its scope.

There are two reasons for this exclusion.

The first reason is based on the nature of the evidence for UFOs. The cultural association of UFOs with alien spacecraft is primarily driven by social trends, not by strong, durable physical evidence that has withstood objective scientific scrutiny. As such, their study has no strong connection to the goals of the committee.

A second reason is related to the scope of work the committee does. Since its inception, the committee has focused on the astronomical search for technological life, for instance using telescopes to search for radio waves, and the policies and practice concerning potential detection of alien life. As such, committee membership comprises primarily astronomers who specialize in these detection methods (in addition to experts in other domains).

The committee appreciates that studies of UFOs are done around the world with varying methods and varying degrees of rigor, but given that those studies are not our focus or our expertise, we have not reviewed them as a committee. Such work is the purview of experts in atmospheric science, aviation, military equipment, aircraft sensors and cameras, aerodynamicists, psychologists, and the like. The vast majority of their work will involve identifying UFOs using methods that committee members are unfamiliar with, and so are beyond the committee’s scope.

Although this committee does not generally include research into UFOs/UAP in its activities, we do not assert that such research is necessarily inappropriate or unscientific, or that Committee members should not individually engage in such work. Although as a committee, we do not collectively evaluate the scientific merit of claims about UFOs being extraterrestrial in origin, we do appreciate the value of such scientific reviews and assessments. Collectively, our activities focus on the astronomy-based search for evidence of extraterrestrial intelligence and closely related topics.

Finally, we note that the committee does occasionally accept abstracts for topics outside its scope at its meetings; however, we expect such exceptions to be rare and well justified.

Minority Report of the Ad Hoc Subcommittee on UFO Studies with Respect to IAA SETI Permanent Committee Business

Jacob Haqq-Misra, Ravi Kopparapu

Summary:

A document drafted by an ad hoc subcommittee advocates for the exclusion of UFO studies from the activities of the IAA SETI Permanent Committee (PC), which nominally represents the majority opinion of the ad hoc subcommittee. As an alternative to this majority opinion, the present document is a minority report that instead argues for the inclusion of UFO studies among the activities of the PC in some cases. We recommend altering the terms of reference to reflect this broadened scope. We acknowledge that not all committee members may be personally interested in scientific investigation of UFOs, but we argue that any UFO investigations that demonstrate genuine scientific merit and relevance to the IAA SETI PC should not be automatically excluded.

Recommendations to the PC:

- Remove this sentence from the [terms of reference](#): “These terms of reference exclude any consideration of UFO phenomena.”
- If the draft terms of reference from 2020 are adopted, then they should not include any statements that exclude the PC from consideration of UFO phenomena.
- Draft a longer document that explains the criteria by which abstracts will be evaluated for relevance to the IAA SETI PC.
- Consider performing further work to explore and constrain any boundaries between ongoing UFO studies and astronomical SETI. Such efforts could include building collaborations with existing organizations that engage in the scientific study of UFOs.

Statement:

The primary goal of the IAA SETI PC is “to examine all aspects of possible future contact with extraterrestrial civilizations, with special reference to international issues and activities.” The terms of reference state that this goal should be supported by activities that include “planetary science missions designed to search for evidence of extraterrestrial life, the astronomical search for extrasolar planets, and the recovery of possible Martian microfossils on the Earth.” Similarly, the draft terms of reference from 2020 state that the IAA SETI PC “examines all topics related to the possible existence of extant or extinct intelligent and/or technologically capable life having arisen beyond Earth” and emphasize that “special attention is paid to international and interdisciplinary issues and activities.”

The question recently arose as to why the current IAA SETI PC terms of reference explicitly exclude UFO (Unidentified Flying Objects) or UAP (Unidentified Aerial Phenomena) studies from consideration. We acknowledge that this exclusion may have been driven by a desire to delineate the scientific activities of SETI from cultural trends that associate UFOs with extraterrestrial life. However, we suggest that the broad exclusion of UFOs/UAP from the IAA SETI PC could undermine the ability of the committee to genuinely “examine all aspects of possible future contact with extraterrestrial civilizations” because such an exclusion neglects an important scenario that is otherwise considered within the scope of traditional SETI.

Earth provides the only known example of technosignatures. Any other concepts for technosignatures arise from projections of future Earth based on concepts that are physically plausible, even if they may not be realistic for the near future of our own civilization. The idea of searching for radio/optical beacons, megastructures, or terraforming all invoke future scenarios of civilization on Earth that could lead to such detectable technosignatures. One such scenario is the idea that extraterrestrials might send exploratory spacecraft to the Solar System. Searching for evidence of such nearby extraterrestrial technology has been described as Solar System SETI or the Search for Extraterrestrial Artifacts (SETA).

The SETA scenario was first proposed by Ron Bracewell in 1960 and has been explored by many other SETI researchers since. A handful of SETA searches have been conducted, which include observations of Earth-moon Lagrange points and analysis of high-resolution lunar images. Such searches are motivated by the scenario that extraterrestrial technology could be resident in the Solar System, and perhaps even on a planetary surface. If extraterrestrial technology actually does exist within the Solar System, then its detection would be directly relevant to the primary goal of the IAA SETI PC.

Free-floating extraterrestrial artifacts might be detectable with current or future observatories. Any artifacts on the surface of a planet or moon might be detectable through analysis of high-resolution images as well as robotic or crewed exploration. But what if an extraterrestrial artifact were to enter Earth’s atmosphere? The observation of such an artifact would technically be considered a UFO/UAP until further data could be collected to assess its identity. Would the observation of such a phenomenon be relevant to the SETI research community?

The blanket prohibition on “any consideration of UFO phenomena” by the IAA SETI PC thereby remains at odds with full exploration of the SETA hypothesis. We acknowledge that the vast majority of UFO/UAP sightings have nothing to do with extraterrestrials, and it is even possible that there are no examples of known UFO/UAP events that would qualify as relevant to SETI. But the SETA hypothesis includes the possibility that an extraterrestrial artifact could enter Earth’s atmosphere. Such a phenomenon would be classified as a UFO/UAP, and thus would be out of scope for the PC. In such a scenario, the exclusion of “UFO phenomena” would prevent the PC from achieving its ultimate goal of “contact with extraterrestrial civilizations.” Likewise, this exclusion would contradict the goal of the PC to examine “all topics related to the possible existence of... technologically capable life.”

We do not suggest that the PC invite any and all UFO/UAP abstracts for consideration, as we fully acknowledge that many such abstracts have nothing to do with scientific SETI or do not follow agnostic scientific methodology. Instead, we urge the PC to clarify the process or rubric by which abstracts will be assessed for relevance. We urge the PC to recognize that the success of SETI will require increasing interdisciplinary collaboration, and so the activities of the IAA SETI PC should be inclusive of all areas of scientific inquiry that could lead to the discovery of extraterrestrial technology.